

Abstracted Atrocities: How Burgess and Klimov Filtered Violence in Opposite Directions

Come and See (1985), the profound anti-war film directed by Elem Klimov, depicts the atrocities committed by the German state in the Byelorussian Soviet Socialist Republic. Shown through the eyes of Flyora, a young boy who is keen to join the Soviet Partisans, Klimov's conceptualization of youth violence shares a deep, ironic connection with the Soviet setting of *A Clockwork Orange*. Burgess's novel was the product of his visit to the Soviet Union, while Klimov's film was the direct result of having lived through a Soviet war. Burgess was a visitor; Klimov was a survivor. In Burgess's 1961 travel essay "The Human Russians," Burgess notes that he arrived in Leningrad expecting to find a "frightening steel-and-stone image of the Orwellian future." What he found instead was "human beings at their most human: or, to put it another way, at their most inefficient."¹ He observed: "That's another thing I liked about Leningrad – the absence of police... perhaps all the police are secret police, and perhaps the only crimes are political crimes," which meant no one was stopping minor misdemeanors such as "drunken disorderliness, rowdyism, soliciting."² Instead, sweating doormen were left to cope with "a loud group of *stilyagi* or teddy-boys, who were shouting and waving broken bottles and demanding to be let into the restaurant... The painted girls solicited and the teddy-boys raged and romped, but no police came."³ Burgess took this real-world "rowdyism" and amplified it into what the main protagonist, Alex, describes as ultra-violence, poignantly demonstrated in this excerpt: "...nor to do the ultra-violent on some shivering starry grey-haired ptitisa in a shop and go smeking off with the till's guts." This suggests that Burgess's first act of abstraction was not inventing the Nadsat language but rather exaggerating the threat to an unbearable state.⁴ It was during this trip that Burgess began formulating "Nadsat," a Russian-inspired argot that combines Romany, Russian, and casual rhyming slang. Burgess contemplated using contemporary "Teddy Boy" slang but feared that using it would quickly render the book outdated by the time it was published; instead, he invented Nadsat.⁵ By rendering the violence through this foreign, stylized language, Burgess creates a psychological barrier that simultaneously alienates and protects the reader from the raw brutality present in *A Clockwork Orange*.

While Burgess relies on a linguistic "shield" to intellectualize violence, *Come and See* operates on the exact opposite structural philosophy. Klimov removes the stylistic buffer: there is no fabricated language, no narrator. He instead filters at the level of content. Klimov depicts the German state's actions not through detached exposition, but through the harrowing, subjective breakdown of Flyora. As a viewer, you are trapped in an inescapable viewing of trauma; Klimov's heavy use of extreme close-ups of Flyora's rapidly aging face is forced onto the audience. While Burgess invites the audience to decode violence through text, Klimov uses the

¹ Anthony Burgess, "The Human Russians," *The Listener*, December 28, 1961, 237.

² Burgess, "Human Russians," 241.

³ Burgess, "Human Russians," 242.

⁴ Anthony Burgess, *A Clockwork Orange*, restored ed., ed. Andrew Biswell (London: Penguin, 2013), 8.

⁵ Andrew Biswell, introduction to *A Clockwork Orange*, by Anthony Burgess, restored ed. (London: Penguin, 2013), xxi.

visceral immediacy of film, soundtracking scenes with a deafening ring to deny the viewer the luxury of looking away. While Burgess abstracted his characters upwards into stylized fiction, Klimov also filtered his work, but in the opposite direction. Drawing from his own childhood trauma of fleeing Stalingrad, Klimov admitted that he had to filter the content downward: “Had I included everything I knew and shown the whole truth, even I could not have watched it.”⁶

Ultimately, both creators recognized that dealing with extreme violence required putting a specific kind of distance between the audience and the atrocity. Burgess achieved this by taking the minor “rowdyism” that he witnessed in Leningrad and filtering it through the Nadsat language so it could be consumed as stylized fiction. Klimov, however, took the unimaginable hell that he lived through and filtered it downwards so that the truth could be borne at all.

⁶ Ronald Bergan, "Elem Klimov," *The Guardian*, November 4, 2003, <https://www.theguardian.com/news/2003/nov/04/guardianobituaries.russia>.